1

The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

Scene 1 · The festival yard

The rooks were louder than the fiddle. Alexander heard them before he reached the top of the hill road, quarrelling in the chestnuts above the gate, and under them, thinner, the fiddle still hunting for its pitch, sawing the same three notes up and down as if it meant to argue them into agreement.

He had been out since seven, sent by his father to look at the second cut on Harrow's Fen, and he had looked at it: a long wet meadow under haze, the ricks standing in it like loaves set out to cool, a sluice gate that wanted seeing to. Now the castle stood before him on its plateau with the morning full on it, and he looked at that too, the way he had been taught to look at any house, his own included, from the oldest part outward. The great square keep first, plainest of all, built by men who had not expected to be visited. Then the chapel spire, and the long eastern range running away along the edge of the plateau with its leaded windows full of light. Below the walls the forest fell steeply away, untouched in living memory. The stone had weathered to the colour of an old hayrick. Someone had tied harvest ribbons, red and yellow, to the iron rings along the gate wall, and they lifted in the small wind as though the wall had agreed to be festive for one week of the year and no longer.

He gave his horse to a stable boy at the gate, and his coat with it.

The cider cart had gone in to the axle just inside, where the ground was always soft and where, every year, somebody forgot that it was. Mr. Fenwick stood beside it with his hat crushed in one fist, a short square man whose voice had been made for calling cattle across three fields.

"Hold hard, bor. Hold *hard*. That's a full load, and if she goes over I'll have every drop out of somebody's hide."

Four estate hands were already leaning on the back of it. The youngest was Carrow, wiry and quick, the Widow Carrow's son, who rode the house's errands faster than anyone in the stables. Alexander did not stop to consider it. He set his shoulder to the tailboard beside them, found the place where the wood was wettest and the grip worst because the good places were taken, and pushed when they pushed. Over his bent back two of the men exchanged a look. He caught it at the edge of his sight and chose not to.

The wheel came up out of the mud with a sound like a boot leaving a bog. The cart rocked, settled, and rolled on toward the trestles with every barrel aboard, and Mr. Fenwick put his hat back on in order to take it off again.

"Much obliged, Master Alexander. Much obliged, sir."

"Not at all, Mr. Fenwick."

He was the tallest of them by half a head, and the only one whose hands were soft. There was a splinter in the heel of his right hand and a bloom of cider across his charcoal waistcoat, and he had tied his cravat a good deal looser that morning than fashion asked, as he did most mornings now. Nobody had said a word about the cravat yet. That was the whole value of a rebellion small enough to deny. He worked the splinter out with his thumbnail while the hands went back to their barrels. They liked him; he knew it. They would sooner have sat down in his father's chair than called him by his Christian name.

"You've his eyes, Master Alexander." The Widow Carrow had come up beside him, small and upright in her Sunday black, to see that her son was in one piece. She nodded across the yard toward the judging table. "Always looking for what's wrong with a thing."

He thanked her, and did not believe her. His eyes were brown, like his father's; everyone said so. But his father looked at a thing and saw what was wrong with it and then, unhurried, saw what to do about it, and Alexander had only ever managed the first half.

His father stood at the judging table in his shirtsleeves, with four marrows of heroic size laid out before him and Farmer Hodge on the far side of them.

"Weight, Your Grace," Hodge said. He was a tall, stooped man who argued with his whole neck. "Always has been weight."

Edward Sterling, seventeenth Duke of Norwich, considered the marrows. He was a solid man rather than an elegant one, built by years of work out of doors, and he stood as though he expected weather. His left hand was in his pocket, turning something over, as it always did when he listened. "It has always been weight, Mr. Hodge, because you have always grown the heaviest. That is a tradition. It is not an argument."

"Girth's naught but show. Any fool can blow a marrow up with water." Hodge did not look at the Widow Carrow's entry, second from the left, with such force that everyone else did.

His father turned his head to look at it too, and the sun found the old pale scars at his temple and along one cheekbone, scars that had been there as long as Alexander could remember and that nobody had ever explained. He drew out his watch, glanced at it, and put it away again, as if the marrow had been allotted a fixed time and was using it. Then he gave the question exactly the pause, grave and unhurried, that Alexander had seen him give to letters arriving under seal from London.

"Then we have two questions before this table, not one. Whether the marrow is large, and whether it is honest."

A ripple ran round the people nearest the table, something short of laughter, the sound tenants made when the Duke said a thing they would repeat at their own fires that night. Alexander, who had stood at the head of a good many tenants' dinners, had never once been given it.

His father looked up then and found him across the yard, and gave him a short nod, the nod for a duty seen to.

His mother had placed herself at the end of the preserves table, near enough to hear every word of the marrow dispute and a careful yard too far to be appealed to by either side. Amelia Sterling wore the festival the way she wore everything, as though it had been arranged for her convenience and she was too gracious to say so. Her dark auburn hair was dressed close beneath a straw bonnet. Her green eyes were on her husband, fond and unhurried, the look of a woman at

a play she had seen before and still enjoyed. As Alexander came up she peeled off one glove, finger by finger, to taste Mrs. Davies's damson cheese.

There had been a winter, the winter he was sixteen, when she had not taken her gloves off at all, not at table and not by the fire, and had told everyone it was the cold. He had teased her about it until she laughed. Now, when she lifted the bare hand to shade her eyes, the light caught the fine silver-grey lines across her palm, which he had long since stopped seeing.

"Should someone rescue him?" he asked.

"My darling, your father has never in his life needed rescuing from a marrow." She drew the glove back on. "Let him have his war. It's the only one I allow him."

"Is it Mr. Hodge's war, or the widow's?"

"It is the marrow's war. The rest of them are simply the ground it is fought over." She looked at his waistcoat. "And you have been pushing carts."

"One cart."

"One cart," she agreed, in a tone that closed the subject.

Thomas Barrow found him at the cider trestles. The under-steward was a big man in a coat too formal for the work he did in it, fair-haired and freckled to the knuckles from twenty summers out of doors, and he held his tally book the way other men held a prayer book. He touched his hat.

"Eight barrels in, sir, and two more coming from Thrower's once the cart's been seen to. You'll have been out to the Fen."

"I saw the ricks."

"My father brought the last load up himself last night. Knee and all." Thomas ran a thick finger down a column. "Most estates, a man goes lame, he goes without wage the same week. Not here." He made a mark, and tipped his head at the yard without looking up. "That's eleven families with hay to see their beasts through till spring, off that one meadow. Folk round here call it useless land, being wet half the year. His Grace won't sell it. Never would." He shut the book. "There's my two barrels now."

He went off toward the gate. Alexander stayed where he was.

Harrow's Fen had been a line in his father's ledgers for as long as he had been able to read them, a figure for rents and a figure for drainage and a note in the margin about the sluice. He had ridden the length of it that morning and seen ricks. Now he looked out past the wall toward the haze, and back at the yard, and found that he was counting. Mr. Fenwick, still shouting. The Davies boys fighting over whose turn it was on the swing hung from the lowest chestnut bough. The Widow Carrow, back beside her disgraced marrow, whose son had put his shoulder to the cart beside Alexander's own, and who kept one cow and would keep it through the winter because of a field he had looked at that morning and seen only hay in. He got as far as seven before he lost track of who belonged to which household, and he stood a moment longer in the smoke and the noise, trying to recover the other four.

The fiddle had found its note. Somebody began to clap along.

He went to find his sister.

The kitchen passage was cooler. He kept to the left-hand wall, as he always did, past the stillroom and the butler's pantry, whose door he did not look at, and came out into heat. Mrs. Thompson's kitchen on a festival morning ran on its own laws. She was a broad woman of fifty or so, floured to the elbow, her forearms red from the ovens, and she conducted four girls and a boy with a wooden spoon, and nobody answered back. Ribbons hung from the drying rack above the range. The girls went round Alexander as water goes round a post. Mrs. Thompson herself, passing with a sheet of pastry over one arm, reached up without breaking stride and plucked a straw out of his hair.

"Shows up something terrible on black, that does, love," she said, and was gone.

His sister was sitting in the middle of the great table, among the cooling racks, in a gown of figured blue silk that had no business within a mile of a kitchen. Its hem was muddied from the yard. A jam tart was balanced on her knee, and there was a crescent of flour on one cuff. Catherine was nineteen and had never in her life been still: one heel drummed against the table leg, and her fingers were breaking the edge off the tart in small pieces and not eating them. Her auburn hair had come down on one side into the waves it was always escaping into. The heat had put colour in her face, so that the little dark mark beside her left eye stood out like a full stop. Her eyes were their mother's, the same green, and quicker.

She saw him, and arranged herself. She straightened her back, folded her hands over the tart, and inclined her head with a precision none of her governesses had ever once managed to get out of her.

"Master Alexander," she said. "You look like a portrait of a duke that someone has left out in the rain. And you have brought the yard in on your waistcoat."

"And you have brought the drawing room into the kitchen," he said. "I believe Mrs. Thompson would rather have the yard."

"Off my table, love," Mrs. Thompson said, passing with a tray. "I've pastry wants that end."

Catherine laughed before she meant to and had to put a hand over her mouth. She moved six inches along the table, which seemed to satisfy honour on all sides. "Did you know," she said, "that in Saxony they make a crown out of the last sheaf of the harvest and carry it into the church with ribbons on it, and hang it up all winter until the mice have had half of it? I read it. A whole crown made out of—" Her eyes went past him to the window, and stayed there.

He waited. "Out of wheat," he offered.

"Hm? Oh. Yes." She looked back at him as though he had only that moment come in, and smiled, and put the tart into his hand. "Here. You've earned it, pushing carts."

He ate it standing up, as he had not eaten anything in a kitchen since he was ten years old. When he glanced at the window to see what she had been looking at, there was only the drying yard and the line of washing and, beyond the wall, the road going away between its hedges toward Norwich.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Every detail in this scene that its scene packet does not supply, in the order it appears. Items marked *decided* have since been approved and recorded in the planning documents. Everything else is open to change in the next draft.

Arrival and the castle

- Alexander rode out at seven, sent by Edward to look at the second cut on Harrow's Fen, and comes back up the hill road at about eleven. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- The rooks in the chestnuts above the gate are louder than the fiddle. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- The hay ricks on the Fen stand "like loaves set out to cool," and a sluice gate there wants seeing to.
- Alexander looks at a house "from the oldest part outward," his own included.
- The keep was "built by men who had not expected to be visited."
- The castle stone has weathered to the colour of an old hayrick.
- Red and yellow harvest ribbons are tied to the old iron rings along the gate wall.
- Alexander gives his horse and his coat to a stable boy at the gate.

The cider cart

- The cart is stuck just inside the gate, where the ground is always soft and somebody forgets every year.
- Mr. Fenwick is short and square, with a voice made for calling cattle across three fields. He says "Hold hard, bor."
- Carrow is one of the four hands: the youngest, wiry and quick, the Widow Carrow's son, the fastest rider in the stables. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- Fenwick puts his hat back on "in order to take it off again."
- Alexander is the tallest by half a head and the only one with soft hands. He has a splinter in the heel of his right hand and cider on his charcoal waistcoat.
- His loose cravat is "a rebellion small enough to deny."

- The Widow Carrow, in her Sunday black, tells him: "You've his eyes, Master Alexander. Always looking for what's wrong with a thing." He doesn't believe her.

The judging table

- Four marrows. Hodge is tall and stooped and "argued with his whole neck."
- Edward's left hand turns something in his pocket when he listens (the rifle ball, unnamed). *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- Edward checks his watch during the judging.
- Edward: "That is a tradition. It is not an argument." and "Whether the marrow is large, and whether it is honest."
- The Widow Carrow's entry is second from the left.
- Edward gives the marrow the pause he gives letters arriving under seal from London.

Amelia

- She stands at the end of the preserves table, in a straw bonnet.
- She takes off a glove to taste Mrs. Davies's damson cheese.
- The winter Alexander was sixteen she never took her gloves off and said it was the cold, and he teased her until she laughed. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- "Let him have his war. It's the only one I allow him."

Thomas Barrow and Harrow's Fen

- Thomas holds his tally book "the way other men held a prayer book."
- Extra cider is coming from Thrower's.
- Thomas's father brought the last load of hay up himself, on his bad knee. "Most estates, a man goes lame, he goes without wage the same week. Not here." *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- The Davies boys fight over the swing on the lowest chestnut bough.
- The Widow Carrow keeps one cow.
- Alexander counts seven of the eleven families before losing track.

The kitchen

- Mrs. Thompson runs four girls and a boy with a wooden spoon. Festival ribbons hang from the drying rack.

- She plucks a straw from his hair: "Shows up something terrible on black, that does, love."
- Catherine wears figured blue silk with a muddied hem.
- Catherine says "Master Alexander" and "You look like a portrait of a duke that someone has left out in the rain."
- Alexander: "And you have brought the drawing room into the kitchen."
- Catherine's Saxony harvest crown, made from the last sheaf.
- Alexander eats the tart standing, as he hasn't in a kitchen since he was ten. The window shows the road toward Norwich.